When you flush the toilet, where does the waste go? It goes into the deep state. There is an intricate subterranean web of pipes, pumps and tunnels that runs under our houses and collects our waste, separates it from the supply of drinking water, and either treats or safely disposes of it. Somebody needs to design, construct and maintain that deep web, plug holes in it, monitor pollution levels and pay the workers. That too is bureaucratic work, and we would face a lot of discomfort and even death if we abolished that particular department. Sewage water and drinking water are always in danger of mixing, but luckily for us there are bureaucrats who keep them separate.

Prior to the establishment of modern sewage systems, waterborne infectious diseases like dysentery and cholera killed millions of people around the world.[30] In 1854 hundreds of London residents began dying of cholera. It was a relatively small outbreak, but it proved to be a turning point in the history of cholera, of epidemics more generally and of sewage. The leading medical theory of the day argued that cholera epidemics were caused by 'bad air'. But the physician John Snow suspected that the cause was the water supply. He painstakingly tracked and listed all known cholera patients, their place of residence and their source of water. The resulting data led him to identify the water pump on Broad Street in Soho as the epicentre of the outbreak.

This was tedious bureaucratic work – collecting data, categorising it and mapping it – but it saved lives. Snow explained his findings to local officials, persuading them to disable the Broad Street pump, which effectively ended the outbreak. Subsequent research discovered that the well providing water to the Broad Street pump was dug less than a metre from a cholera-infected cesspit.[31]

Snow's discovery, and the work of many subsequent scientists, engineers, lawyers and officials, resulted in a sprawling bureaucracy regulating cesspits, water pumps and sewage lines. In today's England, digging wells and constructing cesspits require filling out forms and getting licences, which ensure that drinking water doesn't come from a well someone dug next to a cesspit.[32]

It is easy to forget about this system when it works well, but since 1854 it has saved millions of lives, and it is one of the most important services provided by modern states. In 2014, Prime Minister Narendra Modi of India identified the lack of toilets as one of India's biggest problems. Open